This comprehensive revision guide summarizes the key concepts and details from the sources concerning the Bible's nature, authorship, structure, transmission, interpretation, literary forms, and theological themes.

Comprehensive Revision Guide to the Sources

I. The Nature, Authorship, and Publication of the Bible

A. Defining the Bible

The word Bible originates from the Greek term *Τὰ βιβλία* (*Ta BIBLIA*), meaning **"the books"**. The Bible is best understood as a **library of books**.

1. **Nature of the Text:** It is a **pluralistic text** composed of many parts and various literary genres, dealing with God's relationship to the world.
2. **Divine and Human Element:** The Bible is **both the word of God and human word**. The divine message is expressed using human language, circumstances, and cultural settings (e.g., Jewish culture). This combination of divine and human elements is mirrored in the doctrine of **Incarnation**.

B. The Process of Authorship and Publication

The writing of the Bible was a long and complex process. Jer. 36 provides insight into the scheme of writing:

1. **Inspiration:** The word originates from God, who moves human beings to recognize it. This is an **ongoing process**.
2. **Transmission:** God speaks $\rightarrow$ the Prophet receives and dictates $\rightarrow$ the Secretary (like Baruch) writes it down.
3. **Oral Tradition and Memory:** In its original stages, God's word was transmitted **orally**, and its survival depended on **memory**. Memory is selective, changes with new experiences, and tends to remember things in brief. The four canonical Gospels illustrate how memory works, as they present different portraits of Jesus Christ.
4. **Textual Fluidity:** The resulting text was not a definitive product but **fluid and open to additions**. The process involved writing, **re-writing, editing, and re-editing**. This process of interpretation resulted in the expansion of the text.

C. Understanding "Authors"

In biblical times, an **author was perceived as a transmitter** of what people held (a people's treasure), not as an originator of an idea (the modern sense).

1. **Attribution:** Biblical writings in ancient times were often **anonymous**. Names given (e.g., Moses for the Law, David for Psalms) are largely **attributions** to figureheads.
2. **Group Authorship:** We talk of biblical writers not as individuals but often as **groups of writers**, identified by their language, style, and tendencies.
3. **Levels of Publication:** The publication of the Bible involved **Autonomous authors** (committed brief stories to writing), **Collectors** (revised/actualized existing stories), and **Redactors/Editors** (combined writings and added textual segments).

D. Old Testament Writer Groupings

Writers are grouped based on their characteristics:

- **Yahwistic (J) writers:** Likely the first; fond of using the personal name **Yahweh** for God; perceived as naïve, picturing God as a human worker (e.g., planting a garden).
- **Priestly (P) writers:** Concerned with **order, chronology, genealogy, numbers/ages, and cultic laws** (e.g., framing creation in six days with the Sabbath rest). The Exodus Decalogue links Sabbath rest to creation.
- **Deuteronomistic (D) writers:** Highly influential, artistic, and characteristic of **reformers**. Advocated for the **centralization of the cult** (One God, One Nation, One Cult); emphasized the **land** as a gift and a task. The Deuteronomy Decalogue links Sabbath rest to remembrance of slavery, urging people to become **liberators**.
- **Prophetic writers:** Generally disciples of the prophets (who were speakers). Main concern: how the covenant was realized; focus on **justice** (a relational term).
- **Apocalyptic writers:** Figurative, using **visionary language**; often came from backgrounds of oppression; focus is geared toward the **end time** (e.g., Daniel and Revelation).
- **Wisdom writers:** Teachers of wisdom aimed at educating people into **right living** (the highest knowledge).

II. Divisions, Canon, and Transmission

A. Divisions of the Old Testament

The major divisions are the Old and New Testaments. The term "Old Testament" originated with Christians, viewing it as the collection inherited from Judaism.

1. **Hebrew Bible (TaNaK):** Divided into three parts:

- **T (Torah/Law):** The core; the first five books (Gen-Deut), also called the **Pentateuch** in Greek, traditionally associated with Moses.
- **N (Nebium/Prophets):** Interprets the Law; divided into Former Prophets (Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings) and Latter Prophets (Major/Minor Prophets).
- **K (Kethubim/Writings):** Least important; literature includes Psalms, Proverbs, Job, Daniel, Ezra, etc..

2. **Greek Bible (Septuagint/LXX):** A translation of the Hebrew Bible into Greek.
    - **Division:** Fourfold: The Law, Historical, Prophetic, and Poetic writings.
    - **Difference from Hebrew Bible:** It is **longer**, containing about seven additional books (e.g., 1 & 2 Maccabees, Tobit, Sirach, Judith, Wisdom).

B. Canons and Canonical Differences

The word **canon** means a **measuring stick or rod** used for setting the standard, referring to documents considered authoritative for religious teaching and practice.

1. **Two Old Testament Canons:**
    - **Palestinian Canon:** The Hebrew Bible, containing 39 books.
    - **Alexandarian Canon:** The Greek Bible (LXX), used by the Catholic Church and containing extra books.
2. **Terminology for Extra Books:**
    - **Deuterocanonical:** The term Catholics use for the seven additional books in the Greek Bible (admitting they form a second canon).
    - **Apocrypha:** The term Protestants use for these additional books, meaning they are good for reading but are **not inspired**.
3. **Canonization Process:** It was a **gradual, selective process** lasting many years. It was an interchange between the **faith community** and authoritative writings. It was a "process from below," where the faith community decided which books were canonical, with subsequent councils only approving what was accepted.
4. **Criteria for OT Books:** Documents had to root in reliable priestly tradition, reliable prophetic revelation (matching the moral will of God), cultic use (songs), and bearing to wisdom.

C. New Testament Canon and Criteria

There is **no single canon** for the New Testament (e.g., Luther rejected Revelation and Jude). The NT contains **27 documents**.

- **NT Acceptance Criteria:**
    1. **Apostolic Linkage:** The document must have a link with an apostle (e.g., Mark to Peter, Luke to Paul).
    2. **Ecclesial Linkage:** The Church must have found it useful for teaching on faith, and the document must have been written **early on**.

D. Transmission of the Text

The original manuscripts are lost, and modern Bibles stem from later manuscripts.

1. **Languages:** OT was mainly in **Hebrew**, with some Aramaic and Greek. The NT was wholly a **Greek text**.
2. **Old Testament Texts:**
    - **Massoretic Text (MT):** The primary text used in formal study of the OT, dating from the 2nd century CE. The Massoretes stabilized the original consonantal (unvocalized) Hebrew text by adding **vowel points and accents**. The MT is regarded as the **standard text**.
    - **Samaritan Pentateuch (Sam P):** Dates 2nd–1st Century BCE; contains some older readings than the MT but shows characteristics of harmonization/revision.
    - **Qumran Documents (Dead Sea Scrolls):** Dates 1st Century BCE–1st Century CE; closer to the original texts and indicates a **multiplicity of texts existed**.
3. **Textual Types (Comparison):** The Old Testament is referred to as a **diplomatic text** (representative of the whole text), while the New Testament is an **eclectic text** (made from many different manuscripts).
4. **NT Manuscript Style:** Original NT Greek was written in capital letters without spacing (**uncials**); later texts used upper and lower cases (**minuscules**). Over 2500 textual witnesses exist, often disagreeing, categorized into text types based on copying style (free vs. strict).

III. Approaches to Reading and Literary Genres

A. How to Read the Bible

A profitable reading of the Bible must always be a **critical reading**.

1. **Critical Requirements:** Approach the Bible with an **open disposition** (open eye, ears, heart, and mind). Avoid the assumption that you already know everything.
2. **Context:** The most important principle in interpretation is **context**. Reading should be done contextually (sociological, literary, and immediate context). Reading with others safeguards against bias.
3. **Non-Academic Approaches (with critiques):**
    - **Historical/Literal:** Reads the Bible as a book of history, assuming chronological order. Critique: It misses the authors' intention, which was to convey the **significance or meaning** behind events, not just how things happened (e.g., the creation stories concern who God is, not scientific method).
    - **Inspirational/Motivational:** Situates the self in biblical times ("if the Lord did it then he can do it now"). Critique: It can be highly **selective** and leads to uncritical reading.
    - **Literary:** Reads the Bible for entertainment, recognizing it as great literature. Critique: Must remember the Bible is fundamentally **religious literature** and a confessional document.
    - **Theological:** Concerned with reading for meaning about issues (e.g., war, justice). Critique: It can be prone to **bias**, which historically led to supporting evils like slavery or women oppression.

B. Literary Genres: Poetry

Virtually half of the Bible is a poetic text (e.g., Psalms, Lamentations, Proverbs).

- **Key Characteristic: Parallelism (Repetition)**.
    - **Synonymous:** Two clauses express the **same idea** using different words.
    - **Antithetical:** The second line says the **opposite** of the first (contrast using positive/negative expressions).
    - **Synthetic:** The second verse **supplements** the first, forming a logical extension.
    - **Climactic (Ontological):** The second line goes **beyond** the first, often achieved by repeating a word or words.
- **Other features:** Uses images, personification, metaphors, and similes.
- **Types of Poetry:** Profane (had original secular settings, e.g., Song of Songs) and Religious (e.g., Proverbs, Songs of praise/lament).

C. Literary Genres: Prose

Prose material is classified into three types:

1. **Legal Material:** Central to this is the **Decalogue** (two versions in Ex 20:1-17 and Deut 5:6-22).
    - **Casuistic:** Conditional legal formulations (introduced by "when" or "if").
    - **Apodictic:** Prohibitive legal formulations.
2. **Official Records:** Mainly lists (e.g., genealogies, returnees from exile, builders of Jerusalem walls). Also includes annals, epistolary literature, and court orders.
3. **Narrative Material:** Exhibits characteristics of spoken narration (e.g., use of "see," "behold"). Uses repetition to increase tension. The intention/purpose of a narrative is often disclosed only in its **conclusion** (e.g., Gen 11:9 explains the dispersion of humankind). Includes myths, legends, biographies, and autobiographies.

IV. Core Biblical Themes and Values

A. Stewardship

Human beings are created in God's **image and likeness**. This expression is figurative, bearing the same connotation as God breathing life into humanity. It is a **royal language** referring to **power sharing**; humans are made co-creators or **stewards** to take care of the earth on behalf of the creator.

- **Requirements of a Good Steward:**
    - **Faithfulness:** The most outstanding quality; being true to oneself and trustworthy in service.
    - **Alertness:** A sense of preparedness; always doing the intended will of the master.
    - **Wisdom:** Making the best use of our time, realizing that our span on earth is short.

B. Work and Rest

Work was intended by God from the beginning (Gen 2:15); God himself is presented as a worker and Creator.

- **Purpose of Work:** Human work is a reflection and extension of God's action, making human beings co-partners. The ultimate purpose is the **manifestation of the glory of God**.

- **Rest (Sabbath):** Necessary to balance work; commanded in Ex 20:9.
    - **Symbolisms of Rest:** Participation in the **divine repose** (recovering self-image as distinct from the work itself). A symbol of **liberation** (remembering slavery to avoid becoming oppressors). A symbol of **celebration** (a day of delight and thanksgiving).

C. Justice and Love

Justice is an action that establishes the right, providing a person his or her due (fairness). **Righteousness** goes further, encompassing goodness and kindness. **Biblical justice is a relational term**.

- **Justice Demands:** Aiding victims of oppression, knowing the rights of the poor, dealing fairly in the marketplace, showing impartiality, and caring for the hungry and naked. Failure to do justice is to be blind to God's mercy. Justice exists for the sake of **maintaining the world**.
- **Love:** God is love. The Greek term **Agape** (charity) is predominantly a Christian notion.
- **The Command:** Love of God and love of neighbour are the two sides of a coin. Christian love extends beyond the neighbour to encompass **one's enemies**.
- **Nature of Love:** Love is dynamic, realized in **deeds rather than words**; it extends beyond itself; it is costly (not minding being hurt); and it is an ever-enlarging capacity. True love is realized in obedience to God's commands and **service** toward humanity.

D. Freedom and Leadership

- **Freedom:** In the OT, freedom opposes social slavery and is linked to **redemption** (Exodus). The NT advances this to **spiritual freedom** in Christ, meaning freedom from sin, death, and the law. Freedom is attained in truth (John 8:32). A free person does not live for the self but follows the example of Christ, **putting others first** (Christian service is characterized by love).
- **Leadership:** Seen as a form of **stewardship** founded upon God, requiring leaders to account for their conduct.
    - **Core Model:** The Bible advocates for a **servant leadership model**. A leader must lead from the front, serving the good of all, and putting themselves last.
    - **Key Characteristics:** Humility (self-emptying), Compassion (using power for the sake of others), Influence (visionary), Wisdom, **Integrity** (consistency of action), Honesty, and Patience (endurance).

To grasp the vast complexity of the Bible for your examinations, think of it not as a single stream of information, but as a great **reservoir**. The reservoir is fed by many historical springs (the oral traditions and memory), shaped by various human engineers and architects (the J, P, D, and prophetic writers, who revised and edited), and delivered through different pipes (the MT, LXX, and various textual versions), but all intended to nourish the land (humanity) with God's truth and guidance for living as faithful stewards.